

Michigan race will shape Democrats' 2028 primary narrative

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July tariff overhaul hits Brazil hardest

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Section 301 litigation will likely take until mid-2027 to resolve

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Washington will move toward selective restrictions on Chinese AI

Michigan race will shape Democrats' 2028 primary narrative. Abdul El-Sayed looks like the heavy favorite to win Democrats' Senate primary in Michigan today, off the back of a stellar round of polling last week.

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The consequences of the primary, which has pitted the progressive El-Sayed against the moderate Rep. Haley Stevens (D-MI), and which has generated an unusual degree of bitterness between the two sides, will reverberate over the next year, setting up both progressive and moderate narratives for the 2028 presidential cycle.

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Nominating a genuine progressive like El-Sayed in a swing state like Michigan is an untested strategy for Democrats. If El-Sayed loses to the Republican candidate, Mike Rogers, in the general election, it will feed concerns among moderates about the electability of progressive candidates in the swing states that Democrats need to win to clinch an Electoral College majority.

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If El-Sayed wins the general election, meanwhile, progressives will take it as a vindication that they can indeed win in swing states—even if that win occurs in a national environment that leans more heavily Democratic than would be typical in a presidential-election year.

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If progressives can assuage their electability concerns with a win in Michigan, that would be a boon to progressive presidential candidates like Reps. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (D-NY) or Ro Khanna (D-CA) in the primary. Electability matters deeply to Democratic voters, with Super Tuesday exit polls in 2020

indicating that Democratic primary voters prioritized candidates who “can beat Trump” over those with whom they agreed on all the issues.

July tariff overhaul hits Brazil hardest. New Section 301 forced labor duties replaced the expired 10% Section 122 global tariff last month, applying to the US's 60 largest trading partners.

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The new forced labor and Brazil duties marginally increase the overall US tariff rate to 11.2%, from 10.9%; the AETR was 15.5% before the Supreme Court struck down global IEEPA tariffs.

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Brazil is hit the worst by the tariff overall, moving from a US AETR of 10.9% to 17.6%. China continues to face the highest US AETR at 27.2%, with overcapacity tariffs still to come (yet expected to be small enough to avoid retaliation). The EU, Taiwan, and the UK are among the biggest beneficiaries, with their AETRs seeing small reductions.

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Overcapacity tariffs will likely bring the US AETR to 12.8% once a Section 301 investigation concludes; this would target a different group from the forced labor duties, and in combination with it would bring countries' tariff rates closer to those agreed to under IEEPA.

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For more, please see US's July tariff overhaul hits Brazil hardest , 3 August 2026.

Section 301 litigation will likely take until mid-2027 to resolve. A coalition of states sued in federal court to block the Trump administration's new Section 301 tariffs on 60 trading partners over their policies on forced labor.

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This is the largest suit yet and adds to the growing set of cases challenging the Section 301 tariffs; a number of small businesses also filed suit before the Court of International Trade last month.

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Litigation is in very early stages and will likely take at least nine months, and likely longer, to resolve. The timeline on challenges to IEEPA-based tariffs last year is the most instructive precedent; in that case, it took ten months from the first suits (in April 2025) to an eventual Supreme Court ruling (in February 2026).

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Unlike with the IEEPA tariffs, there is no strong legal consensus on how courts will approach the mass Section 301 tariff, which plaintiffs argue goes beyond the intention of the law. Courts could decline to interfere with the executive's determination of trade-discriminatory practices, thus leaving the tariffs in place, but conservatives on the court could well see the tariffs as a violation of the same “major questions doctrine”—limiting the powers that Congress can confer to the executive—that led them to vote to strike down the IEEPA tariffs.

Washington will move toward selective restrictions on Chinese AI. Chinese AI companies are rapidly closing the capability gap with US frontier models. In response, Washington will shift focus from chips to model and algorithm controls.

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Chinese open-weight models are increasingly approaching the capabilities of cutting-edge US models, without access to sensitive chips. Chinese firms have found methods to train their models without reliance on computing power, raising questions about whether dominance in compute power alone can sustain the US frontier edge.

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Driven by separate concerns from the intelligence community, the Department of the Treasury, and US AI firms, Washington is eyeing expanding restrictions from semiconductors to broader model and algorithm controls. Restrictions risk triggering broader escalation, including additional Chinese controls on rare earths or supply chain security measures.

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Amid these competing pressures, the administration will likely use the information and communications technology and services (ICTS) rule to restrict subscriptions to Chinese AI applications—as it has with Chinese vehicle software—or impose government use or procurement regulations. A blanket ban remains unlikely as the immediate next step.

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For additional background, please see: China's AI surge will push Washington toward selective restrictions , 30 July 2026.

Quote of the Day

"I mean, he can add an apology to the damages part of his lawsuit, but my guess is he's going to be looking for money. He may be the first customer of the anti-weaponization fund." - Sen. John Kennedy (R-LA) speaking to reporters about former Olympian David Hearn, who the Justice Department attempted to prosecute for damaging the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool before moving to dismiss the charges. Trump is vocally advocating Hearn's continued prosecution and reportedly considering dismissing US Attorney for the District of Columbia Jeanine Pirro for her conclusion that vandalism was not behind the pool's damage.

On the Radar

27 July – 28 August: House on recess

4 August: Michigan primary election

10 August – 11 September: Senate on recess

19 August: Section 338 tariffs on Canada go into effect

3 November: National midterm elections

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